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Jagannath Temple, Puri

The **Jagannath Temple** is a Hindu temple dedicated to Jagannath, a form of Vishnu. It is located in Puri, Odisha, on the eastern coast of India.[4] As per temple records, King Indradyumna of Avanti built the main temple.[5] The present temple complex was rebuilt from the eleventh century onwards on the site of the earlier shrines, excluding the main Jagannath temple, and was begun by Anantavarman Chodaganga, the first ruler of the Eastern Ganga dynasty.[6] Many of the temple rituals are based on Oddiyana Tantras which are the refined versions of Mahayana Tantras as well as Shabari Tantras which are evolved from Tantric Buddhism and tribal beliefs respectively.[7] The local legends link the idols with aboriginal tribes and the daitapatis (servitors) claim to be descendants of the aboriginals.[7] The temple is one of the 108 *Abhimana Kshethram* of the Sri Vaishnavite tradition.

The temple is renowned for its annual Ratha Yatra, chariot festival, which honors the three deities - Jagannath, Balabhadra and Subhadra.[8] During the festival, the three principal deities are pulled on large and elaborately decorated *raths*, or temple cars. The worship is performed by the Bhil Sabar tribal priests, as well as priests of other communities in the temple.[9] Unlike the stone or metal icons found in most Hindu temples, the image of Jagannath is carved from spruce wood and is ceremoniously replaced every 12 or 19 years with an identical replica.[10] The temple is one of the Char Dham pilgrimage sites. It is also famous because many legends believe that Krishna's heart was placed here, and the material that it is made from damages the heart, so they have to change it every seven years.[11]

The temple is sacred and holy to all Hindus, and especially in those of the Vaishnava traditions. Many great Vaishnava saints, such as Ramanujacharya, Madhvacharya, Nimbarkacharya, Vallabhacharya and Ramananda were closely associated with the temple.[12][13] Ramanuja established the Emar Matha

Jagannath Temple, Puri

The Jagannath Temple at night

Religion	
Affiliation	Hinduism
District	Puri
Deity	Jagannath
Festivals	Ratha Yatra · Chandan Yatra · Snana Yatra · Nabakalebara
Governing body	Shree Jagannath Temple Office, Puri, Shree Jagannath Temple Managing Committee, Puri

Location	
Location	Puri
State	Odisha
Country	India

in the south-eastern corner of the temple, and Adi Shankaracharya established the Govardhan Math, which is the seat of one of the four Shankaracharyas. It is also of particular significance to the followers of Gaudiya Vaishnavism, whose founder, Chaitanya Mahaprabhu, was attracted to the deity, Jagannath, and lived in Puri for many years.[14][15]

Location in Odisha

Jagannath Temple, Puri (India)

Coordinates	19°48′17″N 85°49′6″E
Architecture	
Type	Kalinga Architecture
Creator	Indradyumna
Completed	1161 CE[1]
Specifications	
Length	650 feet (east to west)[2]
Width	644 feet (north to south)[2]
Height (max)	214 feet 8 inches[2]
Site area	10 acres[2]
Temple	31
Materials	▪ Stone for the temple ▪ Neem wood for the idols[3]
Elevation	65.47 m (215 ft)
Website	
https://www.shreejagannatha.in	

History

The temple was rebuilt by the King of the Eastern Ganga dynasty, Anantavarman Chodaganga, in the 11th century CE, as described by the Kendupatna copper-plate inscription of his descendant, Narasimhadeva II and Rajendra Chola from the mother side.[1] Anantavarman was originally a Shaivite, and became a Vaishnavite sometime after he conquered the Utkala region, in which the temple is located, in 1112 CE. A 1134–1135 CE inscription records his donation to the temple. Therefore, the temple construction must have started sometime after 1112 CE.[16]

According to a story in the temple chronicles, it was founded by Anangabhimadeva II. Different chronicles variously mention the year of construction as 1196, 1197, 1205, 1216, or 1226.[17] This suggests that the temple's construction was completed or that the temple was renovated during the reign of Anantavarman's son, Anangabhima.[18] The temple complex was further developed during the reigns of the subsequent kings, including those of the Ganga dynasty and the Gajapati dynasty.[19]

The temple annals, the Madala Panji, records that the Jagannath temple has been invaded and plundered eighteen times.[20] The temple is believed to have been attacked by Kalapahad, a Muslim convert general, in the 16th century.[21]

Deities

Jagannath, Subhadra and Balabhadra are the principal deities worshipped in the temple. The inner sanctum of the temple houses images of them, carved from sacred neem wood (*daru*), placed on the jewelled platform (*ratnabedi*). The sanctum also contains the deities Sudarshana Chakra, Madanmohan, Sridevi and Vishwadhatri.[22] The deities are adorned with

different clothing and ornaments according to the season. Their worship predates the construction of the temple and may have originated in an ancient tribal shrine.[23] The earliest known reference to Jagannath appears in the Oddiyana Vajrayāna Tantric text *Jñānasiddhi* by Indrabhuti, which begins with an invocation of the deity.[24][note 1] In *Sarala Mahabharata*, Sarala Das presents Lord Jagannath in multiple forms, emphasizing his connection to Krishna. He also described Lord Jagannath as being one with Krishna, Rama, and Buddha, reflecting a synthesis of the different faith traditions.[26]

Char Dham

Jagannath Puri

Rameswaram

Dwarka

Badrinath

Legends

According to legends recorded in *Madala Panji*, the construction of the first Jagannath temple was commissioned by King Indradyumna, a Malava king mentioned in the *Mahabharata* and the *Puranas*.[27]

Artwork of Ratha Yatra in Puri, 1818

Indradyumna commissioned the construction of a monument for Jagannath that was intended to be the tallest in the world. The construction was said to measure 1,000 cubits (457.2 meters) in height. He invited Brahma, the cosmic creator, to consecrate the temple and its images.[28]

According to traditional accounts, the origins of the Jagannath temple trace back to the end of the *Dvapara Yuga*, when the original image of Jagannath was said to have manifested near a banyan tree by the shore in the form of the Indranila Mani (the Blue Jewel). It was said to be so dazzling that it could grant instant *moksha*. The god Dharma sought to conceal it within the earth and succeeded. In the *Kali Yuga*, Indradyumna wanted to find that mysterious image. To achieve that he performed severe penance. Vishnu then instructed him to go to the seashore at Puri, where he would find a floating log from which the image could be carved.[29][30]

Engraving sketch of front gate of Jagannath Temple, 1891

Indradyumna then discovered the log of wood. He performed a yajna, from which Narasimha appeared and instructed that Narayana be manifested as a fourfold expansion: *Paramatma* as Vasudeva (Krishna),*Vyuha* as Samkarshana (Balabhadra), *Yogamaya* as Subhadra, and *Vibhava* as Sudarshana. After this, Vishwakarma appeared in the form of an artisan and prepared images of Jagannath, Balabadra and Subhadra from the tree.[31]

When this log, radiant with light, was seen floating in the sea, Narada told the king to make three deities out of it and place them in a pavilion. Indradyumna got Vishwakarma, the architect of gods, to build a magnificent temple to house the deities, and Vishnu himself appeared in the guise of a carpenter to make the deities, on condition that he was to be left undisturbed until he finished the work.[29][32]

But just after two weeks, the queen of Indradyumna became very anxious. She took the carpenter to be dead as no sound came from the temple. Therefore, she requested the king to open the door. Thus, they went to see Vishnu at work, at which the latter abandoned his work, leaving the deities unfinished. The deity was devoid of any hands. But a divine voice told Indradyumna to install them in the temple. It has also been widely believed that in spite of the deity being without hands, it can watch over the world and be its lord. Thus, the idiom.[29][32]

Statue of Aruna, the charioteer of Surya, the Sun God, on top of the Aruna Stambha in front of the *Singhadwara*.

Entry and *Darshan*

Non-Hindus (excluding Jains, Sikhs, Buddhists) and foreigners are not permitted to enter the temple.[33][34] Such a rule is believed to have existed since the temple was built, and at present, it often becomes a subject to controversy and debates that have lasted for several decades.[35][36][37] According to Ganeshi Lal, the former Governor of Odisha, foreigners can enter the temple only if he/she can meet the Gajapati servitors and the Shankaracharya, then he/she could also be allowed to witness Jagannath. But, this theory has not wielded influence yet, and continues to be a subject of longstanding debate.[38] The temple is open everyday from 5:00 am to 10:30 pm.[39]

The Ratha Yatra in Puri in modern times, showing the three *raths* chariots of the deities with the temple in the background

Cultural integrity

Starting from Jagannath himself, history has it that he was a tribal deity, adorned by the Bhils and Sabar people, as a symbol of Narayana. Another legend claims him to be Nilamadhava, an image of Narayana made of blue stone and worshipped by the tribals. He was brought to Nilagiri, the blue mountain, or Nilachala, and installed there as Jagannath, in company with Balabhadra and Subhadra. The images made of wood are also claimed to have their distant linkage with the *Vanvasis*, or forest dwellers, as a system of worshipping wooden poles. To cap it all, the Daitapatis, who have a fair share of responsibilities to perform rituals of the temple, are claimed to be descendants of the hill tribes of Odisha, also believed to be a close relative of Jagannath. Hence, the beginning of the cultural history of *Shrikshetra*, known as the cultural capital of Odisha is found in the cultures of Hindu tribes. The three deities came to be claimed as the symbols of *Samyak Darshan*, *Samyak Jnana* and *Samyak Charita*, usually regarded as Ratnatraya, the triple gems of the Jain culture, assimilation of which leads to omniscience and *Moksha* (salvation).[40]

Acharyas and Jagannatha Puri

All of the renowned *acharyas*, including Madhvacharya, have been known to visit this *kshetra*. Adi Shankaracharya established his Govardhan Math here. Guru Nanak had visited this place with his disciples, Bala and Mardana. Chaitanya Mahaprabhu of Gaudiya Vaishnavism stayed here for 24 years, declaring that the love of God can be spread by chanting the Hare Krishna mantra. Vallabha visited the temple and performed a 7-day recitation of the *Srimad Bhagavata*. His sitting place is still famous as his *baithakji*, literally translating to his seat. It confirms his visit to Puri.[41]

Some of the pandits who participated became jealous of the young Vallabha, and wanted to test him. The next day was Ekadashi, a fasting day where one must fast from grains. The pandits gave Vallabha rice *prasad* of Lord Jagannath, for which the temple is still famous. If Vallabha ate it, he would break his vow of fasting, but, if he did not take it, he would disrespect Jagannath. Hence, Vallabha, with all honour and respect, accepted the prasad in his hand. He stood there in the temple, spent the rest of the day and night, explaining the shlokas of the greatness of prasad, and ate the prasad the next morning after sunrise.[42]

The Sikh aarti, *Gagan mein thaal*, was recited by the first Sikh guru, Guru Nanak, in 1506 or 1508,[43][44][45][46] during his journey, called udasi, to east India,[44][45] at the revered Jagannath Temple, Puri. This *aarti* is only sung, not performed with any platter and/or lamps, etc.

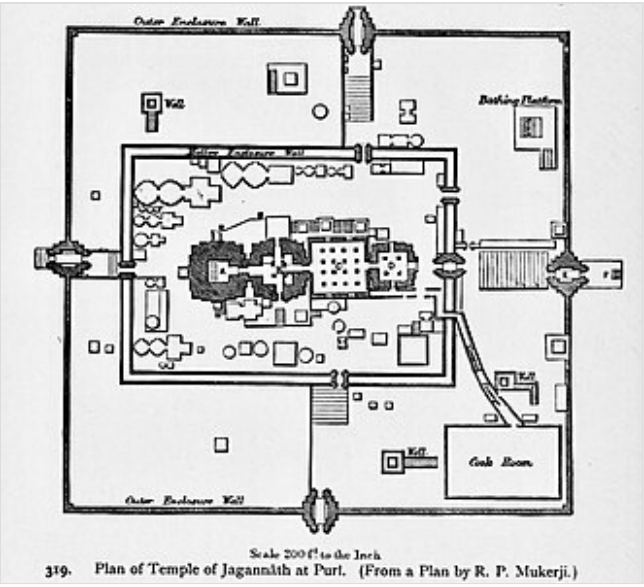
Char Dham

Bird's eye view of Jagannath Temple

The temple is one of the holiest Vaishnava Hindu *Char Dham* sites, the four divine pilgrimage sites, the other being Rameswaram, Badrinath and Dwarka.[47] Though the origins are not clearly known, the Advaita school of Hinduism propagated by Adi Shankaracharya, who created Hindu monastic institutions across India, attributes the origin of Char Dham to the seer.[48] The four temples lie across the four cardinal points, or four corners of India, and their attendant temples are Badrinath Temple at Badrinath in the north, Jagannath Temple at Puri in the east, Dwarakadheesh Temple at Dwarka in the west and Ramanathaswamy Temple at Rameswaram in the south. Though ideologically, the temples are divided between the sects of Hinduism, namely Shaivism and Vaishnavism, the four pilgrimage sites are fully Hinduism.[49] The journey across the four cardinal points of India is considered sacred by Hindus, who aspire to visit these temples at least once in their lifetime. Traditionally, the trip starts at the eastern end from Puri, proceeding in a clockwise direction, in a manner typically followed for circumambulation in Hindu temples.[50]

Architectural description

The temple complex covers an area of over 37,000 square metres (400,000 sq ft), and is surrounded by high fortified wall. This 6.1 metres (20 ft)-high wall is known as *Meghanada Pacheri*.[51] Another wall known as *kurma bedha* surrounds the main temple.[52] It contains at least 120 temples and shrines. With its sculptural richness and fluidity of the Kalinga architecture, it is one of the most magnificent temples of India.[53] The temple has four distinct sectional structures, namely–*Deula*, *Vimana* or *Garbhagriha* (sanctum sanctorum), where the triad deities are lodged on the *ratnavedi*, or throne of pearls. In Rekha Deula style, there is the *Mukhashala*, (frontal porch), the *Natamandapa*, also known as the *Jagamohan* (audience/dancing hall), and the *Bhogamandapa* (offerings hall).[54] The main temple is a curvilinear temple, and crowning the top is the *Neelachakra*, an eight-spoked wheel of Vishnu. It is made out of Ashtadhatu, an alloy of eight metals, and is considered sacrosanct.[55] Among the existing temples in Odisha, the temple of Lord Jagannath is the highest. The temple tower was built on a raised platform of stone, rising to a height 65 metres (214 ft), above the inner sanctum where the deities reside, dominates the surrounding landscape. The pyramidal roofs of the surrounding temples and adjoining halls, or mandapas, rise in steps toward the tower, like a ridge of mountain peaks.[56]



Site plan of Jagannath Temple, c. 1910

A. Main Sanctum (*Garbha-Griha, Deul*)

B. Audience Hall (*Jagamohana, Pidha Deul*)

C. Dancing Hall (*Nat-Mandap, Nata Mandir*)

D. Offering Hall (*Bhoga-Mandap, Bhog Mandir*)

E. Main Gate (*Singha Dwara*)

F. (*Aruna Stambha*)

Nila Chakra

The *Nila Chakra* (lit. blue discus) is the discus mounted on the top of the shikhara of the Jagannath temple. As per custom, everyday a different flag is waved on the Nila Chakra. The flag hoisted on the Nila Chakra is called the *Patita Pavana* (lit. "Purifier of the Fallen"), and is equivalent to the image of the deities placed in the sanctum sanctorum.[57]

The *Nila Chakra* is a disc with eight Navagunjaras carved on the outer circumference, with all facing towards the flagpost above. It is made up of Ashtadhatu and is 3.5 metres (11 ft) high, with a circumference of about 11 metres (36 ft).[58]

The *Singhadwara*

The *Singhadwara*, which in Sanskrit means "The Lion Gate", is one of the four gates to the temple, and forms the main entrance. The *Singhadwara* is so named because of two huge statues of crouching lions existing on either side of the entrance. The gate faces eastward, opening on to the *Bada Danda* or the

"Grand Road".[59] The *Baisi Pahacha*, or the flight of twenty-two steps, leads into the temple complex. A deity of Jagannath known as *Patita Pavana*, which in Sanskrit means the "saviour of the downtrodden and the fallen", is painted on the right side of the entrance. In ancient times, when untouchables were not allowed inside the temple, they could pray to the Patita Pavana. The statues of the two guards to the temple, Jaya and Vijaya, stand on either side of the doorway.[60] Just before the commencement of the Ratha Yatra, the deities of Jagannath, Balabhadra and Subhadra are taken out of the temple through this gate. On their return from the Gundicha Temple, they have to ceremonially placate Goddess Lakshmi, whose deity is carved atop the door, for neglecting to take her with them on the Yatra. Only then, the goddess allows them permission to enter the temple. A magnificent sixteen-sided monolithic pillar, known as the Aruna Stambha, stands in front of the main gate. This pillar has an idol of Aruna, the charioteer of the sun god, Surya, on its top. One notable fact about the Aruna Stambha is that prior to its current location, it was located in the Konark Sun Temple.[61][62] Later, the Maratha guru, Brahmachari Gosain, brought this pillar from Konark.[63]

The *Singhadwara* in 1870, showing the lion sculptures with the Aruna Stambha in the foreground

Other entrances

Apart from the Singhadwara, which is the main entrance to the temple, there are three other entrances facing north, south and west. They are named after the sculptures of animals guarding them. The other entrances are the *Hathidwara* or the Elephant Gate, the *Vyaghradwara* or the Tiger Gate and the *Ashwadwara* or the Horse Gate.[64]

The Ashwadwara Gate

Minor temples

There are about thirty smaller temples and shrines within the Temple complex where active worship is regularly conducted.[64] There are some temples are considered significant and generally visited before the main temple of Jagannath:.[64] the Ganesha temple near the *kalpavata* banyan tree, Vimala Temple, Nilamadhaba temple, Gopalaballava temple and Lakshmi temple.

The Vimala Temple (Bimala Temple) is considered one of the most important of the Shakta pithas.[64] It is located near Rohini Kund in the temple complex. Until food offered to Jagannath is offered to goddess Vimala it is not considered Mahaprasad.[64] The temple of Lakshmi, the consort of Jagannath, has an important role in rituals of the main temple.[64]

There are other shrines dedicated to Kanchi Ganesha, Shiva, Surya, Saraswati, Bhuvaneshwari, Narasimha, Rama, Hanuman.[64]

The Mandapas

There are many mandapas, or pillared halls on raised platforms within the temple complex meant for religious congregations. The most prominent is the Mukti Mandapa, the congregation hall of the holy seat of selected literate Brahmins.[65]

Cluster of minor temples in the southern part of Jagannath temple complex, including the Vimala Temple (extreme right), c. 1890

Daily food offerings

Daily offerings are made to the deity six times a day. These include:

- The offering to the deity in the morning that forms his breakfast, and is called Gopala Vallabha Bhoga. It consists of seven items i.e., Khoa, Lahuni, sweetened coconut grating, coconut water, and rice grain sweetened with sugar known as Khai, curd and ripe bananas.
- The Sakala Dhupa forms his next offering at about 10 am. This generally consists of 13 items, including the Enduri pitha and the Mantha puli.
- The Bada Sankhudi Bhoga forms the next offering, consisting of Pakhala with curd and Kanji payas. The offerings are made in the Bhog Mandapa, about 61 metres (200 ft) from the Ratnabedi. This is called the Chatra Bhog, which was introduced by Adi Shankaracharya in the eighth century to help pilgrims share the temple food.
- The Madhyanha dhupa forms the next offering at the noon.
- The next offering to the deity is made in the evening at around 8 pm, known as Sandhya Dhupa.
- The last offering to the deity is called the Bada Singhara Bhoga.[66]

The *Dola Mandapa* in 1890, where the annual *Dol Yatra* is held.

Shopping in Swargadwar Market

Swargadwar Market in Puri is known for its vibrant collection of souvenirs and local handicrafts. Visitors can find a variety of items, including Jagannath murtis (idols), sankhs (conch shells), Pattachitra paintings, seashell crafts, and Odisha handlooms.[67] Bargaining is common in the market, allowing travellers to negotiate prices for unique mementos of their trip.

Rosaghara

The temple's kitchen is the second largest in the world.[53][68][69][70] Tradition holds that all the *Mahaprasad* that is cooked in the temple kitchen is supervised by Goddess Lakshmi, the empress of the temple herself, and that if the food prepared has any fault in it, a shadow dog appears near the temple kitchen, a sign of her displeasure. If the shadow dog is seen, the food is promptly buried and a new batch is cooked.[71] All 56 varieties of food produced are vegetarian and prepared without onions and garlic.[72]

Festivals

There are elaborate daily worship services. There are many festivals each year attended by millions of people. The most important festival is the Ratha Yatra, or the chariot festival, in June or July. This spectacular festival includes a procession of three huge raths, or chariots, bearing the deities of Jagannath, Balabhadra and Subhadra through the *Bada Danda*, or the Grand Avenue of Puri, until their final destination to the Gundicha Temple.[73] Others are *Pana Sankranti*, also known as Vishuva Sankranti and Mesha and Sankranti, in which special rituals are performed at the temple.[74]

Ratha Yatra festival in Puri, a painting by James Fergusson

Anavasara or Anasara

Every year, the main deities of Jagannath, Balabhadra, Subhadra and Sudarshan, after the holy Snana Yatra on the Jyeshtha Purnima, go to a secret altar, named *Anavasara Ghar*, where they remain for the next dark fortnight, or Krishna paksha. Hence, devotees are not allowed to view them. So devotees worship at the nearby temple of Alarnath at Brahmagiri, an icon of a four-handed Vishnu, as a manifestation of Jagannath.[75] Devotees get the first glimpse of the deities on the day before Ratha Yatra, which is called *Navayouvana*. It is said that the deities fall in fever after taking a huge bath, and they are treated by the special servants, named Daitapatis, for 15 days. During this period, cooked food is not offered to the deities.[76]

Ratha Yatra at Puri

The Jagannath triad are usually worshipped in the sanctum sanctorum of the temple at Puri, but during the month of Ashadha, or the monsoon month, usually falling in month of June or July, they are brought out onto the *Bada Danda*, or the divinity street, and travel (3 km) to the Gundicha Temple, in huge chariots, or raths, allowing the public to have the *Darshana*, or the holy view of the deities. This festival is known as Ratha Yatra, meaning the journey (*yatra*) of the chariots (*raths*). The Rathas are huge wheeled wooden structures, which are built anew every year and are pulled by the devotees with ropes. The chariot for Jagannath is approximately 14 metres (45 ft) high and 11 metres (35 ft) wide, and takes about 2 months to construct.[77] The artists and painters of Puri decorate the cars and paint flower petals and other designs on the wheels, the wood-carved charioteer and horses, and the inverted lotuses on the wall behind the throne.[78] The huge chariots of Jagannath pulled during

Pahandi Bije during Ratha Yatra at Puri

Ratha Yatra is the etymological origin of the English word 'Juggernaut'.[79] The Ratha Yatra is also termed as *Shri Gundicha Yatra*.[80]

The most significant ritual associated with Ratha Yatra is the *Chhera Pahara* (lit. sweeping with water). During the festival, the Gajapati king wears the outfit of a sweeper, and sweeps all around the deities and their chariots in the *Chhera Pahara* ritual. The Gajapati king cleanses the road before the chariots with a gold-handled broom, and sprinkles sandalwood water and powder with utmost devotion. As per the custom, although the Gajapati King has been considered the most exalted person in the Kalinga kingdom, he still renders the menial service to Jagannath. This ritual signified that under the lordship of Jagannath, there is no distinction between the powerful sovereign Gajapati king and the most humble devotee.[81]

Moreover, the ruling dynasty instituted the Ratha Yatra at the completion of the great temple around 1150 CE. This festival was one of those Hindu festivals that was reported to the Western world very early. Odoric of Pordenone, a Franciscan friar from Pordenone in modern Italy, visited India in 1316–1318, some 20 years after Marco Polo had dictated the account of his travels while in a Genoese prison.[82][83] In his own account of 1321, Odoric reported how the people put the deities on chariots, and the King, Queen and all the people drew them from the "church" with song and music.[84][85]

Drawing of Ratha Yatra, Puri, from the book, '**Account Of The Temple Of Jagannath, 1895**'

Niladri Bije

Celebrated on Ashadha Trayodashi,[86] *Niladri Bije* is the concluding day of Ratha Yatra. On this day, deities return to the *Ratnabedi*.[87][88] Here, Jagannath offers Rasgulla to Goddess Lakshmi to enter into the temple.[89][90]

Gupta Gundicha

It is celebrated for 16 days from Ashwin month's Krishna dwitiya to Vijayadashami.[91] As per tradition, Madhava, along with Durga, (known as *Durgamadhaba*), is taken on a tour of the temple premises. The tour within the temple is observed for the first eight days. For the next eight days, the deities are taken outside the temple on a palanquin to the nearby Narayani temple situated in the Dola mandapa lane. After their worship, they are brought back to the temple.[92]

The *Singhadwara* of the temple at present

Nabakalebara

Nabakalabera is a ritual associated with Jagannath,[93] which takes place every 8, 12 or 19 years, when one lunar month of Ashadha is followed by another lunar month of Ashadha. Meaning "New Body", the ritual involves installation of new images in the Jagannath Temple and the burial of the old images at the temple at *Koili Vaikuntha*. The festival is witnessed by millions of people and its budget exceeds ₹41,000,000 (US$480,000).[94] More than three million devotees are estimated to have visited the temple during the Nabakalevara in 2015, making it one of the most visited festivals in the world.[95]

Management

After independence, the Government of Odisha, with a view to getting better administrative system, passed "The Puri Shri Jagannath Temple (Administration) Act, 1952".[96]

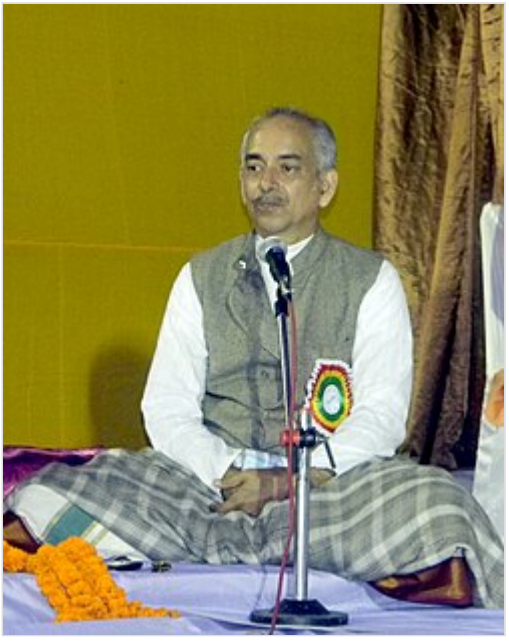
Dibyasingha Deba, the incumbent Gajapati king and King of Puri, is the current *adhyasevak* (chief servitor) of the temple.[97][98] He took the role in 1970 at the age of 17, after the death of his father, Birakishore Deb, then King of Puri.[99]

Security

The backside of the Jagannath temple with the *Koili Baikuntha* garden in the foreground

The security at the temple has increased ahead of Ratha Yatra, the homecoming festival of the deities of Jagannath temple. In the wake of terror alert on 27 June 2012, the security forces were increased to ensure smooth functioning of the crowded Ratha Yatra and Suna Besha.[100] As part of the modernisation of the temple premises and surroundings, the temple's security force has been further advanced, such as 44 police platoons with 30 police officers each, and 135 CCTV cameras with advanced face-scanning technology have been installed in the premises, to cater to more pilgrims and visitors and provide them with enhanced security.[101]

Shree Jagannath Heritage Corridor



Shri Dibyasingha Deb, the incumbent Chief Servitor of the Temple

The *"Shree Mandir Parikrama"*, also known as the Shree Jagannath Heritage Corridor (SJHC), is a 75-metre-long corridor around the Jagannath temple. It has been built to provide expansive and unobstructed corridors around the *Meghanad Pacheri* for giving an opportunity to devotees and pilgrims to have better *darshan* with the Temple, *Nila Chakra* and *Meghanad Pacheri*, similar to the Kashi Vishwanath Corridor of the Kashi Vishwanath Temple in Varanasi. The corridor provides several facilities and amenities for giving pilgrims and visitors a hassle-free and memorable experience, and for strengthening safety and security of the temple and the devotees.[102] Construction began on the corridor after Chief Minister Naveen Patnaik and the incumbent King of the Gajapati Empire and of Puri, as well as the *adhyasevak*, or the chief servitor of the Jagannath temple, Dibyasingha Deba, laid the foundation stone for it in November 2021.[103] It was inaugurated and opened to the public by Chief Minister Naveen Patnaik and King Dibyasingha Deba on 17 January 2024.[104]

See also

- Jagannath Temple, Digha
- History of Odisha
- List of historic sites in Odisha
- Jagannath
- Indradyumna
- Char Dham
- Vaishnavism
- Chanakya
- Guru Nanak
- Kalinga architecture
- Gajapati Empire
- Dibyasingha Deba
- Archaeological Survey of India
- Shree Jagannath Heritage Corridor, Puri
- Konark Sun Temple
- Lingaraj Temple
- Kashi Vishwanath temple
- Chari Kshetra

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